Wildlife & Bird Watching at Ocean Forest Ecolodge: Ecotourism on Costa Rica's Osa Peninsula

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Ocean Forest Ecolodge, where the ocean and rainforest meet in sweet caresses.

At Ocean Forest Ecolodge, an eco lodge on Costa Rica's Osa Peninsula, the ocean, the beach and the rainforest meet in a sweet caress. Abundant wildlife, tropical birds and marine life thrive here, singing in joyful glee from first light to dusk, and through the star filled nights!

Many of our guests tell us they see more wildlife at the lodge than in nearby Corcovado National Park. It is a true miracle that, in this day and age, a people-friendly wilderness still exists. Here animals live in their natural element, at peace and in harmony, just steps from your door. This is ecotourism at its best: nature travel that lets you experience the rainforest without disturbing it.

Whether you are a dedicated birder, an ornithology enthusiast, a wildlife photographer or a family planning an eco-friendly vacation, here are the birds and animals you are most likely to see during your stay at Ocean Forest Ecolodge and the surrounding areas to Corcovado National Park, Los Planes and Drake Bay, Costa Rica.

Bird Watching in Costa Rica: A Chorus in Every Tree

The Osa Peninsula is one of the top birding destinations in Costa Rica and Central America, home to hundreds of bird species. For birders and ornithology enthusiasts, the lodge sits right where rainforest birds and seabirds overlap, so a single morning of birdwatching can fill pages of your bird list.

Scarlet Macaws. The stars of the show. Pairs fly over the beach calling loudly, then settle in the beach almond trees to feed. Listen for them at sunrise and in late afternoon.

Toucans and aracaris. The Yellow-throated Toucan croaks from the canopy. The Fiery-billed Aracari, with its orange-red bill and bright belly band, lives only in this corner of Costa Rica and western Panama.

Parrots and parakeets. Red-lored Parrots and White-crowned Parrots (a Pionus parrot) fly over in chattering pairs, while noisy flocks of Orange-chinned Parakeets dart between the trees.

Trogons. Baird's Trogon, found only in this region, along with Black-throated and Gartered Trogons.

Hummingbirds. Twenty-two species of hummingbirds live in our area. The endemic Charming Hummingbird, the Long-billed Hermit and the Purple-crowned Fairy visit flowering plants around the grounds.

Regional specialties. Keen birders look for the Black-hooded Antshrike, Golden-naped Woodpecker and the rare, endangered Yellow-billed Cotinga. Though rare, the dazzling Turquoise Cotinga is a true prize: a flash of brilliant blue and deep purple perched high in a treetop.

Colorful everyday visitors. Cherrie's Tanager, Blue-gray Tanagers, Red-capped Manakins and Pale-billed Woodpeckers. Look too for the Masked Tityra, a pale bird with a black mask and bright red skin around its eyes, perched on bare branches and making its odd, frog-like grunts.

Flycatchers. More than 40 species of flycatchers live in our area. The best known is the bold, yellow-bellied Great Kiskadee, which shouts its own name, "kis-ka-DEE!", from the treetops. Watching flycatchers sally out from a perch to snatch insects in midair is one of the simple joys of a morning on the porch.

Vireos. Nine species of vireos live in our area. These small olive-and-yellow songbirds move steadily through the leaves, gleaning insects, and sing their sweet, repeated phrases throughout the day. Look for the Yellow-green Vireo and the Red-eyed Vireo in the canopy.

Wrens. The famous House Wren fills the days, and even the cabins, with its bubbling song, often nesting right under the eaves. Eight other wren species live in the surrounding forest, including the Riverside Wren and the Black-bellied Wren, whose loud, rich duets ring out from the thickets.

Sparrows. Four species of sparrows live in our area, hopping through the undergrowth and along the forest edges. Watch for the handsome Orange-billed Sparrow, with its bright orange bill and bold black-and-white face. In the grassy clearings, the little Variable Seedeater feeds on grass seeds; the males are glossy black, often marked with white.

Antpittas and antthrushes. Deep in the shade of the forest floor live some of the most sought-after birds for serious birders. Shy antthrushes, like the Black-faced Antthrush, walk the leaf litter with their tails cocked like tiny chickens, while round, long-legged antpittas, such as the Streak-chested Antpitta, reveal themselves mostly by their haunting, whistled songs. Move slowly and listen carefully to find them.

Tanagers and honeycreepers. The Golden-hooded Tanager glows in gold, turquoise and black, like a living jewel. The iconic Red-legged Honeycreeper is pure electric blue with a turquoise cap and bright red legs, and small flocks often feed together in flowering and fruiting trees. The Bay-headed Tanager, with its rusty-red head and shimmering turquoise-green body, is another gem of the canopy.

Puffbirds, jacamars, kingfishers and woodpeckers. Puffbirds sit still and wide-eyed on open branches, waiting for insects to fly past. Glittering green jacamars, with their long, needle-thin bills, snap butterflies out of the air. Kingfishers patrol the streams and river mouths, and eight species of woodpeckers drum on the trees all around the lodge. Watch the trunks closely for the Cocoa Woodcreeper, a warm brown bird that spirals up the bark, bracing itself with its stiff tail, and fills the forest with its loud, laughing song.

Chachalacas, guans and curassows. Gray-headed Chachalacas announce the morning with their loud, rattling chorus. The Crested Guan, a large turkey-like bird, moves through the trees, and the magnificent Great Curassow walks the forest floor. These big game birds are a sign of a healthy, protected forest.

Wood-rails. Gray-cowled Wood-Rails, known locally as *cocalecas*, are common here. They fill Ocean Forest Ecolodge every day with their cackling, enthusiastic calls.

Doves and pigeons. Twelve species of doves fill the air with their soft, hooting calls from dawn to dusk. Look for the White-tipped Dove, the tiny Ruddy Ground Dove, the Pale-vented Pigeon, and the shy, colorful Ruddy Quail-Dove on the forest floor.

The Clay-colored Thrush. Known as the Clay-colored Robin, and to Costa Ricans as the *yigüirro*, this humble brown bird is Costa Rica's national bird. It sings wonderfully during the summer months, and locals say its song calls in the rains.

Migratory birds. From about October to April, songbirds from North America spend the winter with us. The rosy-red Summer Tanager is a favorite, joined by Swainson's Thrush, Broad-winged Hawks, and warblers such as the Chestnut-sided, Yellow and golden Prothonotary Warblers. In the summer months, our dry season, the migratory Baltimore Oriole brightens the treetops in flame orange and black. Many of the shorebirds on our

beach, like the Whimbrel and Spotted Sandpiper, are migrants too. For birders, this mix of resident tropical species and familiar northern visitors makes the Osa Peninsula an exceptional bird watching destination all year round.

The Squirrel Cuckoo. Less common, but seen now and then, this is one of our most curious birds. Rich chestnut with a long, white-tipped tail, it hops and runs along branches so much like a squirrel that many guests do a double take.

Along the shore. Brown Pelicans glide in lines above the waves while Magnificent Frigatebirds hang in the sky. Brown Boobies fish offshore. On the sand and rocks you may spot Whimbrels, Spotted Sandpipers, herons, egrets and kingfishers at the river mouths. Guests also love finding the Bare-throated Tiger Heron, a large heron with beautifully barred feathers that stands perfectly still as it hunts. White Ibises, with their long, curved bills, are seen often probing the sand and river banks.

Birds of prey. Crested Caracaras and Yellow-headed Caracaras are common right on the beach, strolling the sand in search of a meal. A pair of White Hawks, striking in black and white, lives in the valley next to the lodge and is frequently seen soaring over the forest. Among our favorites is the elegant Swallow-tailed Kite, gliding effortlessly over the canopy on its long, deeply forked tail. Watch also for Ospreys, Common Black Hawks, Roadside Hawks, the Laughing Falcon with its haunting call, and other falcons and kestrels darting over the forest edge. High above, the regal King Vulture soars on broad white wings, joined by three other vulture species, including the familiar Black and Turkey Vultures.

Owls. When night falls, the owls take over. The striking Spectacled Owl, known locally as the *olopopo*, wears bold white "spectacles" around its eyes, and its deep, knocking hoots carry through the forest. Eight other owl species share the night with it, making our star-filled evenings a special time for birders.

Costa Rica Wildlife: Monkeys and Mammals in the Canopy

All four of Costa Rica's monkey species live on the Osa, and you can see every one of them along this coast.

Mantled Howler Monkeys. Their deep roar rolls through the forest at dawn, nature's own alarm clock. Their calls are heard at the lodge every day.

White-faced Capuchins. Clever and curious, they forage through the beach trees in lively troops and are a daily sighting at the lodge.

Central American Squirrel Monkeys. Small, golden and playful. The Osa subspecies is endangered, which makes every sighting special. These are always seen in Corcovado National Park.

Spider Monkeys. Graceful acrobats that swing high in the canopy using their tails like a fifth hand.

Sloths. Both two-toed and three-toed sloths hang quietly in the trees. Ask a guide to help you find one; they are masters of disguise.

Coatis, agoutis and raccoons. Large groups of White-nosed Coatis wander the trails, tails held high. Agoutis are common around the lodge, nibbling fallen fruit, and Crab-eating Raccoons search the rocks and beach at low tide.

Anteaters and more. The Northern Tamandua, Collared Peccaries and Neotropical River Otters at the river mouths. Now and then a Tayra, a sleek, dark relative of the weasel, bounds across the grounds.

Baird's Tapir. Tapirs, the largest land mammals in Central America, roam the grounds of the lodge. Seeing this gentle, endangered giant up close is an unforgettable moment.

Wild cats. Ocelots, margays, pumas and even jaguars roam this region. While the puma has become more common now and can be seen at times, the other species though present are rarely seen, but their tracks in the sand are a thrilling reminder of how wild this place remains.

Marine Life: Whale Watching, Dolphins and Sea Turtles

Humpback Whales. The waters off the Osa are a nursery for humpbacks from both hemispheres. Southern whales arrive roughly July to October, and northern whales roughly December to April. Mothers and calves sometimes surface within sight of shore.

Dolphins. Pods of Pantropical Spotted, Bottlenose and Spinner Dolphins often ride the bow waves of boats heading to Caño Island.

Sea turtles. Olive Ridley, Pacific Green and Hawksbill turtles swim these waters and nest on the region's beaches and are often seen at Caño Iland on snorkeling and scuba diving excursions.

Tide pools and reefs. Bright Sally Lightfoot Crabs scuttle over the rocks, while snorkelers find reef fish, rays, sea stars and Queen conch in the clear water around Caño Island.

Rainforest Reptiles, Frogs and Small Wonders

Iguanas and basilisks. Green Iguanas sun themselves in the branches, and spiny-tailed iguanas bask on the beach rocks. The Common Basilisk, nicknamed the "Jesus Christ lizard," sprints across water on its hind legs.

Crocodiles and caimans. American Crocodiles and Spectacled Caimans rest quietly in the river mouths. Admire them from a respectful distance.

Frogs. Night walks reveal Fleischmann's Glass Frog near the streams, its see-through belly showing its tiny beating heart, and jewel-like poison frogs, including the Golfodulcean Poison Frog found only in this region.

Snakes. Boas, Eyelash Vipers and the Fer-de-lance live in the forest. They avoid people, but always watch your step on trails, especially at dusk. The venomous species are rarely, if ever, seen. Far more common are the harmless Cat-eyed Snakes that come out at night, and three color forms of the *sabanera*: a yellow-and-black one, a tan one and a rare pink one. Now and then guests are also delighted by the beautiful lilac-colored banded tree snake.

Butterflies and crabs. Blue Morpho butterflies flash electric blue through the trees. On the beach, Halloween Crabs in orange and purple and countless hermit crabs make every walk an adventure.

Wildlife Watching Tips for Your Costa Rica Eco Lodge Stay

- **Rise early.** Wildlife is most active from about 5:30 to 8:00 am, and again in the late afternoon.
- **Bring binoculars.** Even a small pair turns a distant flash of color into a toucan or a trogon.
- **Walk the coastal trail.** The path along the shore is a great place to spot monkeys, coatis and macaws.
- **Join a guided tour.** Local naturalist guides know where to find sloths, owls, snakes and hidden frogs, both by day and on night tours, when the forest belongs to frogs, insects, bats and other night creatures.
- **Sit still and listen.** Often the best sightings come to those who simply wait on the porch with a cup of coffee.
- **Respect the wild.** Keep your distance, never feed the animals, and leave only footprints.

Plan Your Ecotourism Getaway on the Osa Peninsula

At Ocean Forest Ecolodge, every day brings a new encounter: a macaw at breakfast, a troop of monkeys at noon, a whale's spout at sunset. Book your stay and experience this rare, living harmony between people and wilderness: the heart of responsible, sustainable travel in Costa Rica.

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Field	Value
Focus keyword	Costa Rica bird watching eco lodge
Page title (under 60 characters)	Wildlife & Bird Watching | Ocean Forest Ecolodge, Osa
Meta description (under 160 characters)	See scarlet macaws, monkeys, whales and sea turtles at Ocean Forest Ecolodge, an eco lodge near Drake Bay on Costa Rica's Osa Peninsula.
URL slug	/blog/osa-peninsula-wildlife-bird-watching

Keyword group	Keywords used in the post
Ecotourism	ecotourism, eco lodge, Costa Rica eco lodge, eco-friendly vacation, sustainable travel, responsible travel, nature travel
Bird watching	bird watching in Costa Rica, birding destinations, birdwatching, birders, bird list, ornithology, scarlet macaw, toucan, Fiery-billed Aracari, Baird's Trogon, hummingbirds
Wildlife	Costa Rica wildlife, abundant wildlife, monkeys, sloths, wildlife photographer, wildlife watching, guided night walk

Keyword group	Keywords used in the post
Marine life	marine life, whale watching, humpback whales, dolphins, sea turtles, Caño Island
Location	Osa Peninsula, Drake Bay Costa Rica, Corcovado National Park, rainforest

Photo tips. Name each image file with keywords (for example `scarlet-macaw-osa-peninsula.jpg`). Give each one alt text that says what it shows, such as "Scarlet macaw in a beach almond tree at Ocean Forest Ecolodge."

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